MIL-C-44051
23 September 1981
SUPERSEDING
(See 6.4)

MILITARY SPECIFICATION

CHICKEN, PRECOOKED, FROZEN

This specification is approved for use by all Departments and Agencies of the Department of Defense.

1. SCOPE AND CLASSIFICATION

1.1 Scope. This specification covers frozen, precooked chicken for use by the Department of Defense as an item of general issue.

1.2 Classification. The product shall be of the following types as specified (see 6.1).

Type I - For heating in an oven (see 6.3)
Type II - For heating in a deep fat fryer (see 6.3)

Style 1 - Breast halves, thighs and drumsticks
Style 2 - Breast halves, thighs and wings

2. APPLICABLE DOCUMENTS

2.1 Issues of documents. The following documents, of the issue in effect on date of invitation for bids or request for proposal, form a part of this specification to the extent specified herein.

SPECIFICATIONS

FEDERAL

L-P-378 - Plastic Sheet and Strip, Thin Gauge, Polyolefin
PPP-B-636 - Boxes, Shipping, Fiberboard
PPP-B-1163 - Boxes, Corrugated Fiberboard, High Compression Strength, Weather-Resistant, Wax-Resin Impregnated

Beneficial comments (recommendations, additions, deletions) and any pertinent data which may be of use in improving this document should be addressed to: US Army Natick Research and Development Laboratories, Natick, MA 01760 by using the self-addressed Standardization Document Proposal (DD Form 1426) appearing at the end of this document or by letter.

FSC 8905

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-21T23:35Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

STANDARDS

MILITARY

MIL-STD-105 - Sampling Procedures and Tables for Inspection by Attributes
MIL-STD-129 - Marking for Shipment and Storage
MIL-STD-668 - Sanitary Standards for Food Plants

(Copies of specifications, standards and publications required by contractors in connection with specific procurement functions should be obtained from the procuring activity or as directed by the contracting officer.)

LAWS AND REGULATIONS

US DEPARTMENT OF AGRICULTURE

Regulations Governing the Grading and Inspection of Poultry and Edible Products Thereof and United States Classes, Standards and Grades with Respect Thereto (7 CFR 70)

Poultry Products Inspection Regulations (9 CFR 381)

(Application for copies should be addressed to the US Department of Agriculture, Information Division, Agricultural Marketing Service, Washington, DC 20250.)

United States Standards for Condition of Food Containers

(Application for copies should be addressed to the Mathematics and Statistics Division, Food Safety and Quality Service, U.S. Department of Agriculture, Washington, DC 20250.)

2.2 Other publications. The following documents form a part of this specification to the extent specified herein. Unless otherwise indicated, the issue in effect on date of invitation for bids or request for proposal shall apply.

NATIONAL MOTOR FREIGHT TRAFFIC ASSOCIATION, INC., AGENT

National Motor Freight Classification

(Application for copies should be addressed to the American Trucking Associations, Inc., Traffic Department, 1616 P Street, N.W., Washington, DC 20036.)

UNIFORM CLASSIFICATION COMMITTEE, AGENT

Uniform Freight Classification

(Application for copies should be addressed to the Uniform Classification Committee, Room 1106, 222 South Riverside Plaza, Chicago, IL 60606.)

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-21T23:35Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

(Technical society and technical association specifications and standards are generally available for reference from libraries. They are also distributed among technical groups and using Federal agencies.)

3. REQUIREMENTS

3.1 First article. When specified (see 6.1), the contractor shall furnish samples for first article inspection and approval (see 4.3 and 6.2).

3.2 Material. All material shall be clean, sound, wholesome, and free from foreign and undesirable odors, flavors, and extraneous materials. All materials shall be such and shall be so handled and processed that the final product shall conform to the end product requirements.

3.2.1 Chicken. All chicken shall be processed and chilled under continuous Government Inspection in accordance with the U.S. Department of Agriculture Poultry Products Inspection Regulations (9 CFR 381).

3.2.1.1 Raw chicken. Raw chicken used for this product shall conform to the requirements of table I.

TABLE I. Requirements for raw chicken

Item No.	Requirement
1.	Chicken shall be fresh killed. 1/ Frozen chicken shall not be used.
2.	Chicken shall be broiler-fryers of 2-1/4 to 3-1/4 pounds (1 to 1.5 kg) weight range.
3.	Chickens shall be U.S. Grade A. 2/

1/ Chicken shall be processed subsequent to date of contract. Unless otherwise specified, the ready-to-cook product shall be eviscerated warm followed by immediate chilling of the eviscerated chicken. The chicken shall be chilled to an internal temperature of not higher than 36°F and not lower than 29°F. Not more than 24 hours shall elapse between the time the chicken is chilled and the start of processing.

2/ The interpretation of grading requirements shall be in accordance with standards of quality set forth in Regulations Governing the Grading and Inspection of Poultry and Edible Products Thereof and United States Classes, Standards and Grades with Respect Thereto (7 CFR 70).

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 20260-21T23:35Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

3.3 Processing. The chicken shall be processed as follows:

3.3.1 Chicken parts. The chicken shall be cut into drumsticks, thighs, breast halves and wings when specified (see 6.1). Backs, necks and giblets shall not be used.

3.3.2 Cooking. The chicken shall be fully cooked. Cooking shall be accomplished by any recognized and approved commercial method used to produce a precooked product.

3.3.3 Coating. The chicken pieces shall be coated, using the coating or batter used by the contractor, or commercial coating may be used. The coating or batter shall adhere tightly to the chicken pieces and shall resist chipping or flaking during storage and handling. All breading and batter shall be applied by machine. Hand breading shall not be permitted. Any unused batter or breading in the machine at the end of a day's run shall be discarded. However, used breading may be sifted when necessary into clean containers for use the same day. The coating for type I chicken shall be cooked and of a golden brown color. Type II coating shall not be browned to any degree.

3.3.4 Freezing. The finished chicken pieces shall be frozen individually in a blast freezer operating at -20°F or lower. Precaution shall be taken to prevent freezer burn, and delays between completion of processing and placing in a freezer.

3.3.5 Packaging. The chicken pieces shall be packaged as specified in section 5.

3.4 Finished product requirements. The finished product shall comply with the requirements of table II.

TABLE II. Finished product requirements

Item No.	Requirement
1.	There shall be no foreign odor such as but not limited to burnt, scorched, sour, rancid, musty, or moldy.
2.	There shall be no foreign material, such as but not limited to dirt, insect(s), insect part(s), feces, ingesta, wood, paper, paint, glass or metal.
3.	There shall be not less than 75 percent and not more than 85 percent chicken after coating (see 4.5.1).
4.	There shall be no evidence of undercooked chicken i.e., flesh that is not cooked, blood around the bone.
5.	There shall be not more than one percent by weight of loose breading and frost in each package examined (see 4.5.2).
6.	There shall be no evidence of thawing during holding or shipment as evidenced by chicken pieces adhering to each other.

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-21T23:35Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

TABLE II. Finished product requirements (cont'd)

Item No.	Requirement
7.	When reheated according to the contractor's directions, the chicken pieces shall be golden brown in color with no scorched area and the coating shall be crisp and not soggy.
8.	When reheated according to the contractor's directions, the flavor and odor shall be typical of chicken of the same type.

3.5 Plant qualifications. The product shall originate, be processed, marked and handled in plants which are operated under the Meat and Poultry Inspection Regulations of the U.S. Department of Agriculture. Finished product refrigeration facilities (freezer, storage and shipping) not operating under these regulations shall meet the requirements of MIL-STD-668.

4. QUALITY ASSURANCE PROVISIONS

4.1 Responsibility for inspection. Unless otherwise specified in the contract, the contractor is responsible for the performance of all inspection requirements as specified herein. Except as otherwise specified in the contract, the contractor may use his own or any other facilities suitable for the performance of the inspection requirements specified herein, unless disapproved by the Government. The Government reserves the right to perform any of the inspections set forth in the specification where such inspections are deemed necessary to assure supplies and services conform to prescribed requirements.

4.2 Plant qualification conditions. The product shall be unacceptable if not produced and stored in plants which currently meet the requirements of 3.5.

4.3 First article inspection. When a first article is required (see 6.2), it shall be examined for the defects specified in table VII. The presence of any defect shall be cause for rejection of the first article.

4.4 Quality conformance inspection. Unless otherwise specified, sampling for inspection shall be performed in accordance with MIL-STD-105.

4.4.1 Component and material inspection. In accordance with 4.1, components and materials shall be inspected in accordance with all the requirements of referenced specifications, drawings, and standards unless otherwise excluded, amended, modified, or qualified in this specification or applicable purchase document.

4.4.1.1 Examination of chicken. Examination of the chicken shall be made to determine conformance to the condition and identity requirements of 3.2 and 3.2.1.1. Records of all applicable control data (temperature and storage time) shall be maintained. Nonconformance to one or more conditions, identity requirements or to temperature and storage requirements reflected by actual examination or by records shall be cause for rejection of the involved quantity of product or finished product made therefrom, as applicable. Conformance to the identity requirements shall be ascertained by examination of USDA Grade certificates.

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-21T23:35Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

4.4.1.1.1 Visual examination of raw chicken. In addition to the examination in 4.4.1.1, the chicken shall be examined for the defects listed in table III. The lot size shall be expressed in units of one chicken. The sample unit shall be one chicken. The inspection level shall be S-4 and the acceptable quality level (AQL) shall be 1.5 major B and 6.5 minor defects per hundred units.

TABLE III. Raw chicken defects

Category		Defect
Major B	Minor	
151		Chicken not fresh killed
152		Chicken not Grade A
	201	Chicken not of specified style and weight

4.4.2 End item and packaging examination.

4.4.2.1 Shipping container content examination. The shipping container contents shall be examined for the defects listed in table IV. The sample size shall be eight shipping containers regardless of lot size. The finding of one or more defects shall be cause for rejection of the lot.

Table IV. Shipping container contents defects

Category		Defect
Major B	Minor	
151		Bulk pack contains unauthorized part, i.e. back, neck or giblet. 1/
	201	Bulk pack contains less than 36 pieces 1/
	202	Bulk pack contains pieces which are not all of the same part. 1/
	203	Shipping container with bulk packs contains less than 108 pieces. (36 pieces each of breast halves, thighs, drumsticks, or wings as applicable).
	204	Shipping container with individual portion packs does not contain four intermediate packs.
	205	Shipping container contains pieces not of the type specified.

1/ For this defect, examine one bulk pack from each shipping container in the sample.

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-21T23:35Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

4.4.2.2 Individual portion pack examination (styles 1 and 2 only).

4.4.2.2.1 Intermediate pack examination. The intermediate packs shall be examined for the defects listed in table V. The lot size shall be expressed in units of one intermediate pack. The sample unit shall be one intermediate pack. The inspection level shall be S-4 and the AQL shall be 6.5 defects per hundred units.

TABLE V. Intermediate pack defects

Category	Defect
Minor	
201	Net weight of intermediate pack is less than 9 pounds.
202	Intermediate pack does not contain 16 unit packs.
203	Instruction sheet missing.

4.4.2.2.2 Unit pack examination. The unit packs shall be examined for the defects listed in table VI. The lot size shall be expressed in units of one pack. The sample size unit shall be one pack. The inspection level shall be S-3 and the AQL shall be 2.5 defects per hundred units.

TABLE VI. Unit pack defects

Category	Defect
Major B	
151	Unit pack does not contain three pieces.
152	Unit pack contains unauthorized pieces for the style specified.
153	Unit pack contains unauthorized parts, i.e., backs, necks, giblets.
154	Net weight of unit pack is less than 9 ounces.

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-21T23:35Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

4.4.2.3 Finished product examination. The finished product shall be examined for the defects listed in table VII. The lot size shall be expressed in units of one bulk pack or one intermediate pack as applicable. The sample unit shall be one bulk pack or one intermediate pack as applicable. The inspection level shall be S-3 and the AQL shall be 2.5 major B defects per hundred units. The presence of any major A defect shall be cause for rejection of the lot.

TABLE VII. Finished product defects

Category		Defect
Major A	Major B	
101		Foreign odor, such as, but not limited to burnt, scorched, sour, rancid, musty or moldy. 1/
102		Foreign material such as, but not limited to dirt, insect(s), insect part(s), feces, ingesta, wood, paper, paint, glass or metal.
	151	Less than 75 percent or more than 85 percent of chicken after coating (see 4.5.1). 1/
	152	Type I chicken coating not cooked and golden brown in color.
103		Evidence of uncooked chicken, i.e., flesh that is not cooked, blood around the bone. 1/
	153	More than one percent by weight of loose breading and frost in each package examined see 4.5.2).
	154	Evidence of thawing during holding or shipment as evidenced by chicken pieces adhering to each other.
	155	When heated according to contractor's directions the chicken pieces are not golden brown in color, contain scorched areas and the coating is not crisp. 1/
	156	Flavor and odor not typical of chicken of this type when prepared according to contractor's direction. 1/

1/ Select three pieces of chicken from each sample unit to determine compliance.

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-21T23:35Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

4.4.2.4 Examination of polyethylene bags (primary containers). Examination of polyethylene bags (primary containers) shall be performed in accordance with the applicable requirements of the United States Standards for Condition of Food Containers.

4.4.2.5 Examination of shipping containers. When shipping containers are required to be in accordance with PPP-B-636 or PPP-B-1163, examination for defects in construction, closure and reinforcement shall be in accordance with the quality assurance provisions of the applicable box specification. In addition, the following classification of defects shall be included in the examination: Major: National Stock Number, item description, contract number or date of pack markings missing, incorrect or illegible. Minor: (1) Other required markings missing, incorrect or illegible; (2) Reinforcing bands are metallic or do not contrast with black; (3) Number and direction of reinforcing bands for PPP-B-1163 container not as specified; (4) Instruction sheet missing (bulk pack only). Level C shipping containers shall be examined only for the aforementioned marking defects and for the closure method specified in 5.2.2.

4.5 Methods of inspection.

4.5.1 Examination for percent chicken.

4.5.1.1 Skewer method.

a. Remove a portion from the head of the breading unit, weigh and record weight.

b. Pass a skewer (thread or other means of identifying the portion through the ends of the piece of chicken and return to the belt just before the first batter (if used).

c. Allow the chicken piece to remain on the belt to the packers.

d. Remove the chicken piece at the packers.

e. Remove the skewer and weigh the unit.

f. Percent of chicken shall be determined as follows:

$$\text{Percent of chicken} = \frac{\text{Weight of unbreaded chicken piece}}{\text{Weight breaded chicken piece}} \times 100$$

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 202640-21T23:35Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

4.5.1.2 Washing method.

4.5.1.2.1 Equipment required.

a. Water tap with aerated faucet spray attachment.

b. Balance accurate to 0.01 ounce (0.1 gram).

c. Nut picker.

d. Spatula, 4 inch blade with round tip.

e. Shallow baking pan.

f. US Standard sieve - ASTM-No. 8, 1/2 inch opening, 12 inch diameter.

g. US Standard sieve - ASTM-No. 20, 12 inch diameter.

4.5.1.2.2 Procedure.

a. Weigh sample of frozen breaded chicken. Record weight of sample.

b. Adjust tap water to a flow rate of approximately 3 quarts per minute through an aerated faucet. Remove coating (breading) by lightly rubbing coated (breaded) samples with fingers under running water, being careful not to rub off chicken flesh (using spatula or nut picker as applicable). (The removal of coating (breading) shall be done over stacked No. 8 and No. 20, or equivalent). Place the wet debreaded samples after washing onto the stacked sieves and rinse with a spray attachment, remove top sieve and drain at a 45 degree angle for 2 minutes, then remove samples to weighing pan. Rinse content on the No. 20 sieve and collect any particles other than breading and add to sample unit on balance pan and weigh. Calculate the percentage of chicken material by the following formula:

$$\text{Percent Chicken Material} = \frac{\text{Weight of debreaded sample}}{\text{Weight of breaded sample}} \times 100$$

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-21T23:35Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

4.5.2 Examination for loose coating and frost.

a. Record marked net weight of package.

b. Open package and remove coated chicken portions.

c. Remove from package the loose coating and frost adhering to the and inner surface of the package. Weigh this material. The maximum weight of loose coating and frost tolerated is calculated as follows:

New weight ounces x .01 = ounces of permissible loose coating and frost

5. PACKAGING

5.1 Preservation. The product shall be preserved in accordance with level A.

5.1.1 Level A. Thirty-six pieces of each part of one type only (drumsticks, thighs, and breast halves) shall be bulk packed in a 0.0015-inch thick polyethelene bag made from material conforming to Class 2 of L-P-378. When specified (see 6.1), wing parts may be substituted for the drumsticks, the thighs, or the breast halves. Each bag containing drumsticks, thighs, breast halves or wings shall be securely closed.

5.1.1.2 Individual portion pack.

5.1.1.2.1 Unit pack. Each type II, style 1 (one each of breast half, thigh, and drumstick) or style 2 (one each of breast half, thigh, and wing) product shall be unit packed in a food grade plastic bag. The net weight of product per unit pack shall be not less than 9 ounces. Each unit pack shall be securely closed.

5.1.1.2.2 Intermediate packs. Sixteen style 1 or 2 bags of product unit packed as specified in 5.1.1.2.1 shall be intermediate packed in accordance with commercial practice. The net weight of product per intermediate pack shall be not less than 9 pounds. Each intermediate pack shall be securely closed.

5.2 Packing. The product shall be packed in accordance with level B or C as specified (see 6.1).

5.2.1 Level B. One hundred eight pieces of product of one type only (36 each of drumsticks, thighs, breast halves, or wings, as applicable), bulk packed as specified in 5.1.1.1 or 4 intermediate backs of type II, style 1 or 2 as specified (see 6.1) intermediate packed as specified in 5.1.1.2.2 shall be packed in a snug fitting fiberboard box constructed, closed and reinforced in accordance with style FTC, grade W5c or W5s of PPP-B-636.

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 202610-21T23:35Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

Alternatively, the shipping container shall be a wax-impregnated fiberboard box constructed in accordance with style RSC, class I, type SWCFI, grade 200 of PPP-B-1163. Closure of the wax-impregnated box shall be with hot melt adhesive in accordance with the appendix of PPP-B-636. The packed wax-impregnated container shall be reinforced with two lengthwise bands and one girthwise band in accordance with the appendix of PPP-B-636. All shipping containers shall be reinforced with nonmetallic strapping or pressure-sensitive adhesive filament reinforced tape in accordance with the appendix of PPP-B-636. The reinforcing bands shall be uncolored or of a color which will contrast with black.

5.2.2 Level C. The shipping container shall be in accordance with the Uniform Freight Classification or National Motor Freight Classification, as applicable, except that the closure of fiberboard boxes shall be in accordance with method II as specified in the appendix of PPP-B-636.

5.3 Labeling and marking.

5.3.1 Bulk packs. Labeling of bags is not required. A sheet of white paper containing the contractor's instructions for preparation shall be placed on the top of the closed bags.

5.3.2 Individual portion pack.

5.3.2.1. Unit pack. Labeling of bags is not required.

5.3.2.2 Intermediate pack. Each pack shall be labeled or marked with the following information:

Item identification

Type and style of product

A sheet of white paper containing the contractor's instructions for preparation shall be placed within each intermediate pack.

5.3.3 Shipping containers. Shipping containers shall be marked in accordance with MIL-STD-129. In addition, the following precautionary marking shall be placed on the top of the container in capital letters between 1 and 1-1/2 inches high, all letters being the same height:

PERISHABLE - KEEP FROZEN

(0°F (-18°C) OR BELOW)

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-21T23:35Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

6. NOTES

6.1 Ordering data.

(a) Title, number, and date of this specification.
(b) When a first article is required (see 3.1).
(c) When wing parts are required (see 3.3.1 and 5.1.1.1).
(d) Selection of applicable level of packing (see 5.2).
(e) Type and style (when applicable) of product desired (see 1.2 and 5.2.1).

6.2 First article. When a first article is required, it shall be inspected and approved under the appropriate provisions of DAR 7-104.55. The first article shall be a preproduction sample and shall consist of six bags of the product. The contracting officer should include specific instructions in all instruments regarding arrangements for inspection and approval of the first article.

6.3 Technical information. In general, type I chicken (for oven heating) is golden brown in color and is suitable for use in box type lunches without further heat treatment. Type II chicken (for heating in a deep fat fryer) generally does not have the coating browned to any degree. While the chicken meat is fully cooked, type II chicken has a less attractive appearance than type I chicken before it is heated.

6.4 This specification includes the requirements of Purchase Description LP/P. DES 6-78A dated 18 August 1978.

Custodians:

Army - GL
Navy - SA
Air Force - 50

Review activities:

Army - MD
Navy - MC, MS
DP - SS

Preparing activity:

Army - GL

Project No. 8905-0952

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-21T23:35Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.



Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 202610-21T23:35Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-21T23:35Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

STANDARDIZATION DOCUMENT IMPROVEMENT PROPOSAL

INSTRUCTIONS This form is provided to solicit beneficial comments which may improve this document and enhance its use DoD contractors, government activities, manufacturers, vendors, or other prospective users of the document are invited to submit comments to the government Fold on lines on reverse side, staple in corner, and send to preparing activity Attach any pertinent data which may be of use in improving this document If there are additional papers, attach to form and place both in an envelope addressed to preparing activity A response will be provided to the submitter, when name and address is provided, within 30 days indicating that the 1426 was received and when any appropriate action on it will be completed.

NOTE This form shall not be used to submit requests for waivers, deviations or clarification of specification requirements on current contracts Comments submitted on this form do not constitute or imply authorization to waive any portion of the referenced document(s) or to amend contractual requirements.

DOCUMENT IDENTIFIER (Number) AND TITLE

MIL-C-44051 Chicken, Precooked, Frozen

NAME OF ORGANIZATION AND ADDRESS OF SUBMITTER

☐ VENDOR ☐ USER ☐ MANUFACTURER

1. ☐ HAS ANY PART OF THE DOCUMENT CREATED PROBLEMS OR REQUIRED INTERPRETATION IN PROCUREMENT USE? ☐ IS ANY PART OF IT TOO RIGID, RESTRICTIVE, LOOSE OR AMBIGUOUS? PLEASE EXPLAIN BELOW.

A. GIVE PARAGRAPH NUMBER AND WORDING

B. RECOMMENDED WORDING CHANGE

C. REASON FOR RECOMMENDED CHANGE(S)

2. REMARKS

SUBMITTED BY (Printed or typed name and address - Optional)

TELEPHONE NO

DATE

DD FORM 1 OCT 6 1426

EDITION OF 1 JAN 72 WILL BE USED UNTIL EXHAUSTED

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 202640-21T23:35Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.